DESIGN BRIEF · OCT 2026 · OWNER KR0

DROPFRONT

A capture-point battle you run with a hand of cards, then drop into yourself for short firefights. Set in a dieselpunk war over an industrial outpost.

Genre card tactics with top-down shooting | Platform browser, mouse or touch | Match 5 to 8 minutes | Budget 42.0M tokens

1 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In Dropfront you command blue bots against a red commander for five points on one map: Watchtower, Quarry, Foundry, Refinery and Docks. Every 15 seconds you draw five cards and spend 3 energy to send squads, play tactics or equip gear on your hero. When a point is under attack you can drop in for 20 seconds of top-down shooting while the battle keeps running at quarter speed. Each point you own scores 2 resources a second. First to 2000 wins.

PLAYER FANTASY	WIN A MATCH	LOSE A MATCH
The general who can also grab a shotgun and win the fight personally.	Reach 2000 resources first, or lead when the 8:00 clock runs out.	The enemy reaches 2000 first, or leads at 8:00. Losing any match ends the run.
WIN A RUN		
Win three matches in a row, drafting a new card after each win.		

Every turn is a trade

Energy is short. Squads, tactics, gear and drop-ins all compete for it, and unspent energy is lost.

Short bursts, big stakes

A drop-in lasts 20 seconds and can flip a point, and with it the match.

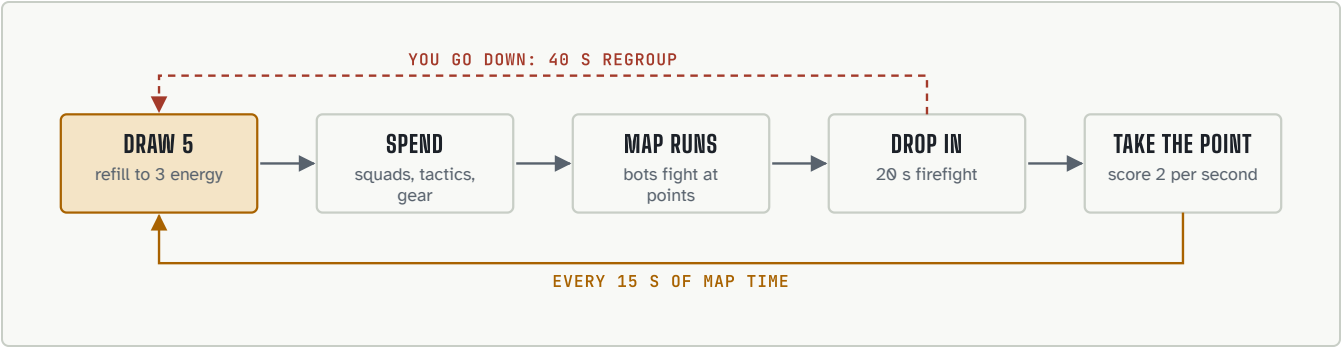
Gear for the situation

Two gear cards at most. Discard one to make room for what the next fight needs.

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2 GAME MECHANICS

Core loop



A command turn comes every 15 seconds of map time, so a match cycles this loop 20 to 30 times.

1. **Draw.** Discard what's left, draw 5 cards, refill to 3 energy.
2. **Spend.** Play squads and tactics on points, equip gear, or scrap up to two cards for +1 energy each.
3. **Watch the map.** Bots walk the roads and fight at points; capture meters swing.
4. **Drop in** for 2 energy at any point with enemies on it, and fight for 20 seconds.
5. **Take the point.** Clear every enemy and the point is yours, locked for 10 seconds, scoring 2 a second.

How you win and lose

WIN

Your score reaches 2000 before the enemy's, or you're ahead when the real-time clock hits 8:00. On a tie, whoever holds more points wins. Win three matches for a full run.

LOSE

The enemy reaches 2000 first or is ahead at 8:00. One lost match ends the run. Going down in a drop-in doesn't lose the match; it costs you a 40-second regroup.

What you press

ACTION	MOUSE AND KEYBOARD	TOUCH
Play a card	Click it, then a highlighted point (or keys 1–9)	Tap it, then the point
Scrap a card for +1 energy	Right-click it, or hover and press X	Long-press it
Drop in	Click a point marked Drop in	Tap the point
Move, aim, shoot	WASD, mouse, hold left click	Hold where you want to go; you fire automatically
Dash or call the bomber	Space; Q then click	Double-tap; tap the gear slot then the target

A turn at the Foundry

3:15	The turn clock ticks its last 3 seconds. You draw Rifle squad, Rifle squad, Feint, Shotgun and Sabotage, and you have 3 energy. You equip the Shotgun (2) and send a Rifle squad to the Quarry (1).
3:20	The map runs. Red dots stream toward the Foundry in the center and a red *Rally* banner flashes over it for two seconds. The Foundry's meter starts sliding red and its ring turns amber: **Drop in**.
3:30	Next turn you scrap Feint and Sabotage for +2 energy and click the Foundry. A drum hits, the camera zooms in, and you're the blue arrow behind cover with your shotgun. Six red discs with health bars are on the capture circle.
3:45	You clear the last disc with 5 seconds left. The Foundry flips blue and locks for 10 seconds, and the score bar at the top starts climbing faster. Your hero regroups for 20 seconds.

The cards

A 17-card starter deck in three types. **Squads** put bots on the map: Rifle squads, Rushers, Heavies, a Sniper nest and a 6-bot Reinforcement wave. **Tactics** bend the battle: Feint, Rally, Hold the line, Flare, Sabotage and Overclock. **Gear** equips your hero for drop-ins: Shotgun, Jump pack, Medic drone and Bomber run. You never steer bots directly; cards are the only way to move the battle.

3 AI ARCHITECTURE

Dropfront has four in-game agents. The red side plays the same game you do, with the same tactic cards and its own hero, and every move it makes shows on the map so you can read it. All of them run on fixed rules inside the game, with no language-model calls during a match.

Enemy commander

WHAT YOU SEE

Every 4 to 6 seconds a red squad of 2 or 3 bots leaves its base. It defends points you're attacking, takes neutral ones and hits your weakest. Its tactic cards flash on the map for 2 seconds.

EFFECT ON PLAY

Tells you where the next fight is. Feint makes it chase a point of your choosing for 8 seconds. After 3:00 its squads get bigger, and after 5:00 it sends two at a time, so a slow start loses.

Enemy champion

WHAT YOU SEE

A red hero drops onto a point, counts as 4 bots there and can't be killed on the map for 20 seconds.

EFFECT ON PLAY

Drop in to fight it yourself: 15 HP, faster than bots, carrying two gear. Beat it and it can't drop again for 30 seconds.

Bots, both sides

WHAT YOU SEE

Dots walking the eight roads, then trading losses on contested points while the capture meter swings toward the bigger side.

EFFECT ON PLAY

Numbers win points. Heavies deal double losses while defending, so they're how you hold ground you've just taken.

Firefight bots

WHAT YOU SEE

When you drop in, up to 8 red bots from that point appear in the arena as discs with health bars, 3 HP each, alongside up to 6 of yours.

EFFECT ON PLAY

The squads you sent with cards fight beside you. Sending bots before dropping in makes the 20 seconds easier.

How the agents play off each other. The commander and champion work as a pair. The champion only drops onto a point the commander already holds against 3 or more of your bots, or one its squads have pushed to neutral. When you see it land, that point was about to flip. That's your signal to spend the 2 energy and drop in.

4 TECHNICAL STRATEGY

Development agents

Twelve AI agents build Dropfront. kr0 directs them and approves every design decision and every file they write.

AGENT	ROLE ON DROPFRONT
creative-director	Keeps every card and rule tied to "every turn is a trade" and the 8-minute match.
technical-director	Decides how the command map and the firefight share one clock, and signs off architecture decisions.
producer	Plans the sprints, tracks spend against the 42.0M-token budget, and moves stories below the cut line when a sprint overruns.
game-designer	Owns the GDD: scoring, capture rules, the card list and the drop-in outcomes.
systems-designer	Tunes capture speed, bot losses and match length, using the headless runner's simulated matches.
economy-designer	Balances card costs, energy and scrapping so a dead hand can still become a drop-in.
gameplay-programmer	Builds the cards, energy, deck, capture meters and the drop-in firefight.
ai-programmer	Builds the enemy commander's squad and tactic choices and the champion's drop rules.
ui-programmer	Builds the hand, loadout bar, score race and turn timer for mouse and touch.
sound-designer	Makes the turn-clock tick, capture and loss chimes, and the drop-in drum.
qa-tester	Runs 1,000 simulated matches before each balance change and hand-plays every finished story.

AGENT	ROLE ON DROPFRONT
`prototyper`	Built the current browser prototype the GDD's numbers come from.

How they hand work over. A new card goes from the game-designer's rule to the gameplay-programmer's code, then to the ai-programmer so the commander can play its mirror, then to the qa-tester's simulated matches. If those matches push the average length past 8 minutes, the producer sends the card back to the game-designer before it ships.

Semester scope

Assumes a 15-week semester ending in one playable vertical slice.

Ships this semester

- One map with five points and eight roads
- The 17-card starter deck and all four gear cards
- Enemy commander, champion and per-match ramp
- Drop-in firefight with the base rifle and gear
- A three-match run with a card draft after each win
- Mouse, keyboard and touch controls

After the semester

- More maps and a larger draft pool
- Music
- Unlocks that carry between runs
- Multiplayer

Constraints

Two clocks, one match

The map keeps running at 25% speed during a drop-in, so the firefight and the command map must share one game clock. Map time and real time are tracked separately, because the 8:00 limit counts real time, drop-ins included.

No model calls during play

The commander decides every 4 to 6 seconds, dozens of times a match. A hosted-model call for each decision would add delay and token cost to every match, so it runs on fixed scoring rules: zero runtime tokens.

Balance by simulation first

The prototype has been tested only by simulation. Each balance change is checked with headless matches, which are cheaper in tokens than hand play, and a person still plays every finished story.

API constraints on the agent crew

- **Context window.** Agents read the GDD one section at a time; the card table is the section most stories load.
- **Rate limits.** At most three agents work in parallel, and never two on the card system at once.
- **Model tiers.** Directors run on the strongest model; specialists run on the session's model.

Token budget

Planning estimate for the semester build. Most tokens are input, because every call re-reads the rules it touches. Actual spend per story goes into the tuning history and the plan is redone at each sprint close.

FEATURE	MAIN AGENTS	TOKENS
Design upkeep and stories	game-designer, producer	1.5M
Map, roads and capture meters	gameplay-programmer	3.0M
Cards, deck, energy and scrapping	gameplay-programmer, economy-designer	3.0M
Bots, movement and point combat	gameplay-programmer	2.5M
Enemy commander	ai-programmer	4.0M
Enemy champion	ai-programmer	2.0M
Drop-in firefight	gameplay-programmer	4.0M
Gear cards	gameplay-programmer	2.0M
Run structure and card draft	game-designer, gameplay-programmer	2.0M

FEATURE	MAIN AGENTS	TOKENS
UI and touch controls, sound	ui-programmer, sound-designer	3.0M
Headless runner, balance runs, playtests	qa-tester, systems-designer	3.0M
Subtotal		30.0M
Rework reserve (40%)		12.0M
Total development budget		42.0M
Runtime tokens per match		0